

Steven Vanden Heuvel

Principal Designer

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SUMMARY

Principal Designer at PayPal (contract via Magnit Global) since December 2025, working as a product designer on consumer checkout and merchant-facing payment flows for 20+ top global brands on weekly sprint cycles. Spent 18 years at MTG Media Group building design systems for 7 B2B brands across responsive web, email, and print. Fintech background spanning consumer finance, financial products, consumer checkout, merchant tooling, and high-stakes payment flows. Comfortable with interaction design at every fidelity, from rough flow sketches through polished production screens. Actively building with agentic tooling (Claude Code and Cursor) as part of my daily workflow. Four-time Jesse H. Neal Award winner.

SKILLS

Design Systems, Atomic Design, Storybook, Service Blueprints, UX Design, UI Design, Visual Design, Interaction Design, Product Strategy, User Research, Prototyping, Wireframing, Accessibility, Financial Products, AI Assisted Workflows (Claude Code, Cursor), Figma

EXPERIENCE

Principal Designer, PayPal

Dec 2025 to Present | Remote, IL | Merchant Enablement Checkout (Contract)

- Designed a modular checkout flow library for grocery, retail, restaurant, and subscription merchants. Covers the full consumer purchase flow from product selection through payment confirmation.
- Produced 20+ complete merchant proposal packages for PayPal's top 100 global brands on weekly sprint cycles. PM brief to final deliverable in 5 days, including wireframes, high-fidelity screens, annotated components, and flow specs.
- On my own initiative, built a Figma plugin that cut per-flow setup from up to 60 minutes down to about 30 seconds across the 38-merchant program, now used by the full Merchant XD team.

VP / Creative Director (Design Systems & Web), MTG Media Group

Oct. 2007 - May 2025 | Chicago, IL and remote | 18 years in responsive web, product, and design systems

Led a 6-person creative team across 7 publication brands and 6 responsive web products at MTG Media Group, building and owning the design system for all 7 properties. Initiated the brand-site rebuilds and introduced mobile-first responsive design, Figma, and Atomic Design through Pattern Lab, and began the team's move to Storybook.js.

- Plate (plateonline.com):** Won 2017 Jesse H. Neal Award for Best Website. Rebuilt as a responsive, mobile first product serving 42,000+ readers with 56,000+ monthly pageviews. 90% of subscribers reported the content shaped their purchasing decisions.
- Project Blackbird (Plate):** Built an interactive oral history product with a dozen video interviews, original photography, and illustrations. Grand Jesse H. Neal Award nominee, top 4 nationally.
- Alt Meat:** Launched a brand, magazine, and website from zero in under 8 weeks as the first major B2B publication in alternative protein. Grew to 22,000 registered users.
- Meatingplace:** Designed a modern responsive rebuild of MTG's highest-traffic daily news site, where 95% of readers reported taking action from content. The brand was acquired before the rebuild launched.
- Built design systems and reusable design tokens for 7 properties, keeping visual and interaction patterns consistent across editorial, marketing, and sales.

AWARDS

- Four-time Jesse H. Neal Award winner (the B2B equivalent of the Pulitzer Prize)
- Grand Jesse H. Neal Award nominee for Project Blackbird, top 4 nationally

EDUCATION

University of Wisconsin-Whitewater, B.A. in Art with emphasis in Graphic Design and Marketing